But one pattern quickly caught her attention. Most of these systems focused on what agents could do, but almost none of them clearly defined what agents should be allowed to do. During a meeting with ACME's identity team, Trudy asked a simple question.

"What exactly are these agents authorized to do in our systems?"

The room went quiet.

The engineers explained that agents accessed internal APIs using the same mechanisms used by applications and employees. Authentication verified that requests came from the correct service or account. But beyond that, authorization decisions were often implicit. If an agent could reach a tool or API, it could usually use it.

Trudy immediately saw the problem. Traditional software follows predictable code paths, so authorization rules can be written with confidence, knowing how the application will behave. Agents are different. They plan actions dynamically, choose tools at runtime, and revise their strategies as they gather new information. In systems like this, authorization can't simply act as a gate at the system's edge. It must become part of the agent's ongoing decision-making process.

This flexibility to replan is what makes agentic systems powerful. It is also what makes them hard to control. Trudy summarized the problem during a follow-up discussion with the engineering team: "Authentication tells us who is making a request," she said. "But agents introduce a new problem. We also need to govern how they behave."

That realization led ACME to a greater challenge. If agents could dynamically plan actions and invoke tools throughout the enterprise, then authorization could no longer be seen as a static barrier at the system's edge. It had to become an ongoing part of the agent's decision-making process. In other words, authorization was no longer just about controlling access; it became about shaping how agents interact with surrounding systems.

Here we will examine how ACME addressed that challenge. We analyze why traditional authorization models have difficulty with agentic systems,